I Bring You Flowers
by William Lang

[FAYE enters pushing a baby carriage. She coos to the baby, tucks it in, & pushes the carriage to the side. After a moment or two JIM enters carrying a newspaper under his arm. As the conversation evolves, we realize the bench is in the courtyard of an institution where the young wife is an inmate and the husband a visitor.]

FAYE: **(Pg 5-8)** It's a lovely day for flowers, isn't it?

JIM: Yes, it is. *[both sit down on the bench. JIM opens the paper]*

FAYE: Do you mind if I ask you a question?

JIM: No, not at all.

FAYE: If all the flowers in the world were stretched end to end, how long would they be?

JIM: To the moon and back.

FAYE: *[with exaggeration]* You're kidding!

JIM: *[puts down paper and raises his hand in the scout salute]* Scouts honor.

FAYE: If all the flowers in the world were put in one big flower pot, how high would that be?

JIM: Four times the height of the Empire State Building.

FAYE: *[with exaggeration]* You're kidding!

JIM: *[raising his hand in the scout salute]* Scouts honor.

FAYE: If all the flowers in the world were each given, one by one, to a little child to hold and smell . . .

JIM: *[walks a few steps away. He cuts FAYE off, with seriousness]* No, Faye. No.

INTRODUCTION

TOGETHER: I Bring You Flowers by William Lang

FAYE: I said if all the flowers in the world were each given to a little child…

JIM: *[interrupting her again]* Faye, ask something else.

FAYE: I want to know the answer to that question. *[pouts, stamps foot]*

JIM: There is no answer to that question. It disappeared.

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FAYE: It didn't!

JIM: It did.

FAYE: Are you sure?

JIM: Yes, I'm sure. *[picks up the paper]* Would you like to read a part of the paper?

FAYE: No, thank you. I think I'll enjoy the flowers. *[pause]* What time is it?

JIM: *[looks at watch]* Ten to ten.

FAYE: Time is so deceiving. I could stay here forever.

JIM: Ask me another question.

FAYE: *[with enthusiasm]* How many chinamen are there in Honolulu?

JIM: *[with enthusiasm]* Half a million and they're all waiters at Wo Fats. Do you remember that day?

FAYE: *[laughing]* Could I ever forget it! We went out and had pizza, remember? **(Pg 10-12)** Remember the ride around Ka'ena point? You were going to show me the island.

JIM: *[with good humor]* You laughed at me, then, didn't you?

FAYE: It is not every day that one's hero gets stuck in the mud and has to be pulled out.

JIM: We could go back to Hawaii.

FAYE: If all the flowers in the world looked alike, would they be beautiful?

JIM: I would bring you flowers every day.

FAYE: Would you?

JIM: Plumeria, orchid—all the flowers I would lay at your feet.

FAYE: Do you love me?

JIM: *[takes her hand]* Let's go back to Hawaii. *[JIM turns away]*

FAYE: **(Pg 16)** *[doubtful]* Jim, do you think we could have as much fun now as we did then?

JIM: More. It would be a second honeymoon.

FAYE: **(Pg 12-14)** Hawaii is gone. It's over.

JIM: No, it's not. *[FAYE begins to cry]* Don't cry. Don't cry.

FAYE: If all the flowers in the world were blue, what color would the ocean be?

JIM: No, Faye, don't! Let's talk!

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FAYE: I'm not ready to talk. Tell me of Hawaii. Tell me of Makaha, of Pats at Punalu'lu.

JIM: No! I want to tell you of the future.

FAYE: *[slight pause]* Answer me a question then?

JIM: All right.

FAYE: If all the flowers—

JIM: Oh, God! *[interrupting; exasperated]* I thought . . . *[walks away a few steps]* what difference does it make.

FAYE: Jim, please understand.

JIM: *[turning and coming up to her]* All right. I'll tell you what I understand. This had got to stop. How long can we go on like this, Faye? *[grabs FAYES arms, shakes her]* How long?

FAYE: Why must you always come back to that? *[FAYE pulls away]* Why can't you leave well enough alone?

JIM: Because it's there! It lives and breathes. *[then, diversionary]* Let's go back to Hawaii.

FAYE: **(Pg 16+)** Who would take care of her? *[goes to stroller, adjust blankets]*

JIM: No one. *[shakes head]*

FAYE: No one? Who would take care of my Lela?

JIM: *[going to her with intensity]* Honey, honey. It's time to face up to the fact that our Lela is dead and has been for a year.

FAYE: No. My Lela's taking a nap!

JIM: She's not taking a nap!

FAYE: How can you be so cruel? When she wakes up, I'll show her all the flowers. *[sings to herself]* Rock-a-bye baby on the tree top.

JIM: When was Lela born?

FAYE: You know that.

JIM: You tell me. I forgot.

FAYE: She was born two days before Christmas. She was our present from Santa Claus.

JIM: That's right. And how many years ago was that?

FAYE: It was . . .

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JIM: It was four and a half years. Now tell me, Faye, if Lela was four and a half years old, would she still nap in a baby carriage?

FAYE: If all the flowers in the world had thorns, would people ever pick them?

JIM: Answer me! Would she?

FAYE: If all the flowers . . .

JIM: Lela is dead!

FAYE: **(Pg 22)** No. You're wrong, Jim. She's alive. In the morning she wakes up and calls for me. She has orange juice for breakfast and we talk and she dresses her dolls. It's true, Jim. *[picks the "baby" up from the carriage]* Lela.

JIM: *[taking the doll from her]* This is not Lela! This is a doll. You buy these things in stores, you take them home to your children and they play with them. This is not Lela. This is a doll. A doll! *[has an idea, puts the doll back in the carriage, calms himself, then speaks]* Do you remember the kid's pool with the metal frame I had so much trouble putting together?

FAYE: The pool Lela swims in?

JIM: Yes, that's it. The pool that Lela swims in. It's still in the garage . . . heavy . . . You needed a PhD in engineering to put it together.

FAYE: (Pg 24-25) Lela loves this pool.

JIM: Why don't you get her? Maybe she'd like to swim in it.

FAYE: Really?

JIM: Really. Why don't you get her and sit there by the pool with her while I go get the fire started. *[pantomimes starting a fire]* Remember how we used to barbeque in Hawaii all the time?

FAYE: Yes.

JIM: When I lit the fire, do you remember what I said to Lela?

FAYE: You said . . .

JIM: I said, watch the big flames. *[pantomimes fire going up]* Poof! And then Lela got out of the pool to get the ball. Take Lela out of the pool, honey, to get the ball. Go ahead.

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FAYE: All right. *[she does so; pantomime]*

JIM: Then what happened?

FAYE: **(Pg 27)** Lela got out and went around the side of the house.

JIM: **(Pg 26)** Did you say anything to her?

FAYE: Yes. I said, don't go in the road.

JIM: Tell it to ***her***, honey.

FAYE: *[calls out to Lela]* Don't go in the road, Lela baby.

JIM: And what did she say?

FAYE: She said I won't Mommy.

JIM: That's right. And then what happened.

FAYE: I sat down. I was tired.

JIM: No, you didn't sit down. What did you do, Faye, honey? Do you remember?

FAYE: **(Pg 28-30)** I . . . I . . . I heard a sound

JIM: What sound? What was the sound, Faye?

FAYE: It was loud and grating.

JIM: And then . . .?

FAYE: And then we heard nothing and we ran and . . .

JIM: And what happened??

FAYE: *[in tears as she remembers]* NO! NO! Oh, God NO!

JIM: We picked up our Lela and put her on the table and she didn't say anything.

FAYE: She wasn't in the road, Jim, she wasn't even in the road.

JIM: *[tenderly]* Faye.

FAYE: Jim, why us? Of all the people in the world, why us?

JIM: I don't know. *[walks away a few steps]*

FAYE: Where does that leave us now, Jim?

JIM: It leaves us free to go home.

FAYE: And what then? *[said simply]* Lela, Lela, Lela.

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JIM: Honey, honey. It's time to face up to the fact that our Lela is dead and has been for a year, and that you have a husband who is alive and breathing and who needs you and wants to take you away from this flower garden and all the memories of Lela and start making some new memories.

FAYE: Lela likes teriyaki.

JIM: Faye, honey, please, don't start that again. Please

FAYE: Teriyaki and Kool-Aid. She likes orange Kool-Aid with teriyaki. I'll fix her some.

JIM: Faye. No! Stop it!

FAYE: *[pantomiming the action as she speaks]* You just open the package like this and pour it into the pitcher. We empty the package in the big pitcher and pour in water and add sugar. Maybe daddy would like some. Give it to Daddy.

JIM: *[spoken at the same time as FAYE's lines]* Faye, honey, stop! Stop it. I love you. Stop it, please, oh God, stop it.

FAYE: *[picks up the doll and cuddles it; she's lost in her memory of Lela]* Where is Daddy going? Lela, Daddy is going to work. Say bye-bye to daddy. *[JIM shakes his head and exits; he doesn't look back]* Lela, look at the pretty flowers. Lela, if all the flowers in the world could speak, what do you think [they'd say]?

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